

SCAFFOLD

SUPPORTS TERTIARY HOW

FOR WHY-WHAT · WHAT-WHY

Definition-of-Done Cards

A card completed at the start of any piece of work that specifies, objectively, what finished means. **Done becomes a fact, not a feeling.**

THE DRAIN

Without an external definition, "done" for a tertiary HOW profile is a feeling, and the feeling arrives early, usually when the interesting part is over. The gap between felt-done and actually-done is where rework, resentment from receivers, and quality surprises live.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The card externalizes the judgment. Before work starts, it captures the objective criteria, the person who confirms them, and, just as important, what is explicitly not included. Finishing becomes checking a card, which requires no precision instinct, only the discipline to write the card first.

Anatomy of a card

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|-------------------------|---|
| 1 The deliverable | What is being produced, in one plain sentence. |
| 2 The criteria | Three to five checkable facts that must be true. No adjectives. |
| 3 The confirmer | The named person who says done. Not you. |
| 4 The not-included line | What this work explicitly does not cover, agreed up front. |

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 **Write the card before starting.** Five minutes at kickoff. After work begins, the definition bends toward the feeling.
- 2 **Make every criterion checkable.** "Reviewed by legal" is checkable. "High quality" is not.
- 3 **Agree it with the receiver.** The card is a contract. Their signature criteria beat your assumptions.
- 4 **Check the card, then stop.** When criteria are met, ship. The card also protects you from polishing past done.

WHAT IT WON'T DO

A card cannot rescue vague work; if you cannot write checkable criteria, the work itself is not yet defined, which is a finding in its own right. And meeting the card is the floor, not the ceiling; judgment still matters above it.

IN THE KIT

Blank card pads (print)

Example cards for common deliverables

Criteria writing guide

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 3 The Last 10% Protocol · **Tool 11** Good-Enough Threshold · **Tool 2** Pre-Flight Checklist Library